KETOTIFEN

Takes weeks to work

Weight gain

CHEMICAL NAME 4-(1-methylpiperidin-4-ylidene)-4,9-dihydro-10H-benzo[4,5]cyclohepta[1,2-b]thiophen-10-one (fumarate)

CLASS H1 antihistamine and mast-cell stabiliser

TRADE NAMES Zaditen · Zaditor (eye drops) · Ketofen

THERAPEUTIC USES / INDICATIONS

- Prophylaxis of allergic asthma in children (some countries, add-on).
- Allergic rhinitis, chronic urticaria.
- Allergic conjunctivitis (eye drops).

PHARMACODYNAMICS

- **H1 antagonist** + stabilises mast cells (↓ release of histamine and leukotrienes).
- Reduces eosinophil accumulation.

ADMINISTRATION

- **PO** tablets/syrup with food, twice daily.
- **Eye drops:** 1 drop twice daily; remove soft contact lenses (wait 15 min).

SIDE & ADVERSE EFFECTS

SIDE EFFECTS (COMMON)

- Drowsiness (initially), dizziness.
- Increased appetite, weight gain.
- Dry mouth.

ADVERSE EFFECTS (SERIOUS)

- CNS excitation in children (irritability, insomnia).
- Thrombocytopenia with oral hypoglycaemics (rare).
- Seizures (history of epilepsy).

DOSAGES

- **Children ≥3 yr (and adults where licensed):** 1 mg twice daily, morning and evening.
- **Children 6 months–3 yr:** 0.05 mg/kg twice daily.
- **Eye drops (0.025%):** 1 drop twice daily.

CONTRAINDICATIONS & CAUTIONS

- Epilepsy (lowers threshold).
- Hypersensitivity.
- **Caution:** use with oral antidiabetics.

KEY INTERACTIONS

- **Oral antidiabetics:** reversible thrombocytopenia.
- **CNS depressants:** ↑ sedation.
- Do not stop asthma medicines abruptly when starting.

PHARMACOKINETICS

- **Onset:** antihistamine effect hours; prophylactic effect 6–12 weeks.
- Metabolised in liver.
- Excreted in urine. **t½:** 21 h.

NURSING MANAGEMENT

- Monitor weight and appetite.
- Explain that benefit in asthma prevention takes weeks.
- Monitor platelets if on oral antidiabetics.
- Eye drops: technique and lens advice.

PATIENT EDUCATION

- Continue other asthma medicines.
- Benefit builds slowly over weeks.
- May increase appetite and cause drowsiness.

KEY POINTS

- Antihistamine + mast-cell stabiliser.
- Weight gain, drowsiness.
- Slow onset (weeks).
- Eye drops for allergic conjunctivitis.

SOURCES CHECKED **[483]** Zaditen 0.25 mg/ml, eye drops, solution. (UK SmPC) **[484]** Ketotifen monograph (Health Canada)

Full references p. 432–457